Thrifty Bites

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About Thrifty Bites

Thrifty Bites was created to support families across the Upper Cumberland region who face the daily challenge of stretching limited food budgets while still providing healthy, comforting meals at home. By transforming the original printed Thrifty Bites cookbook into a bilingual, mobile-friendly digital platform, our goal is to make these resources easier to access, easier to use, and easier to share. Every recipe on Thrifty Bites costs under $10 and uses simple, widely available ingredients. The platform allows users to filter recipes, save favorites, and plan meals in a way that fits their budget and lifestyle. The Backpack Program—one of the key programs our audience interacts with—provides children with bags of free, kid-friendly, easy-to-prepare food to take home on weekends and school breaks.

Problem Description

- Accessibility:

The printed cookbook was not easily accessible to every family who needed it. Physical copies could be lost, damaged, or simply unavailable when families needed quick meal ideas. Digitizing the cookbook also opens the door to accessibility improvements such as adjustable text sizes, screen-reader compatibility, bilingual support, and simplified navigation, making the resource more inclusive for families with diverse needs and abilities.

- Changing Prices

Food prices fluctuate constantly due to supply chain issues, seasonal availability, and economic conditions. A digital platform allows for dynamic price updates, ensuring that families receive accurate, realistic cost estimates when planning meals.

- Changing needs of the community

The needs of the community have evolved since the original cookbook was created. Families are navigating new challenges — from rising food costs to limited transportation to shifting work schedules — and they require tools that adapt alongside them.

Objective

- Searchable Recipes

We aimed to make recipes easier to find, easier to browse, and easier to use. Instead of flipping through pages, families can now search by ingredient, cost, category, or dietary needs.

- Collection of Resources

Beyond recipes, we wanted Thrifty Bites to serve as a hub for essential community information. Families often rely on multiple programs — food banks, Backpack Programs, community partners, and local support services — but that information can be scattered or outdated. Our objective was to centralize these resources in one place, making it easier for families to find help when they need it. This includes up-to-date community resources, partner organizations, shelf-life guidelines, and other practical tools that support food security and household stability.

- Admin Dashboard

To keep the platform relevant and responsive, we needed a way for administrators to easily update content. The admin dashboard was designed to give authorized staff the ability to add new recipes, modify existing ones, update community resources, manage partners, and adjust site content without needing technical expertise. This ensures the website can evolve alongside the community and remain accurate, engaging, and useful over time.

- User Accounts

We aimed to give families a more personalized experience by allowing them to create user accounts. With accounts, users can save favorite recipes, build shopping lists, track ingredients, and access their preferences across devices. This feature supports long-term engagement and helps families build habits around affordable, nutritious cooking. User accounts also open the door for future enhancements such as personalized recommendations or multilingual settings.

Conclusions

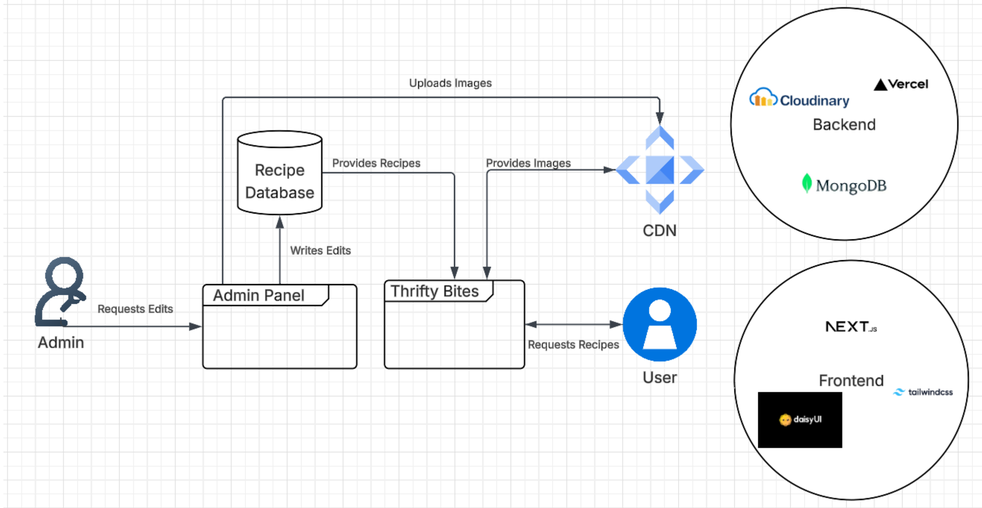
The Thrifty Bites digital platform represents a major step forward in making the original cookbook more useful, adaptable, and accessible for the families it serves. By moving from a static printed booklet to a dynamic online resource, we created a system where recipes can be updated, searched, filtered, and accessed from any device. This shift ensures that families can always find affordable meal ideas that match their ingredients, budget, and dietary needs, even as food prices and community circumstances continue to change. The platform also introduces practical tools that support everyday cooking and meal planning. Features such as ingredient checklists, clear step-by-step instructions, and visual recipe cards help users cook confidently, while filtering and search options reduce the time and stress involved in deciding what to make. The inclusion of editable community resources, partner information, and images ensures that the site remains a living, accurate, and visually engaging hub for support. These elements make Thrifty Bites more than a recipe collection—it becomes a centralized resource for families navigating food insecurity. On the administrative side, the admin dashboard allows staff to update recipes, modify resources, and manage content without technical barriers. This ensures that the platform can grow and evolve alongside the community, staying relevant long after its initial launch. While user accounts are partially implemented—allowing users to register but not yet save recipes or lists—the foundation is in place for future personalization features. Completing this functionality will enable families to build favorites, track ingredients, and maintain a consistent experience across devices.

References

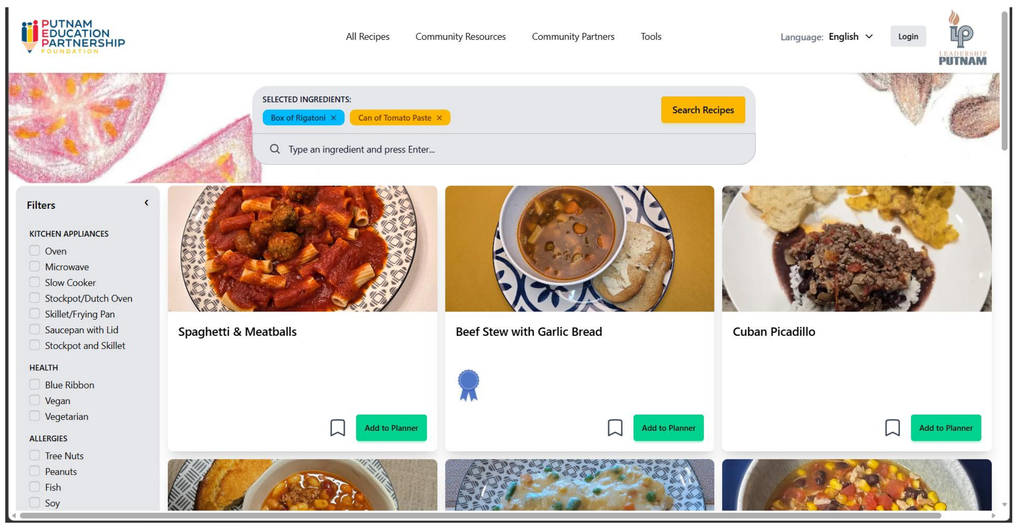
Thrifty Bites

Our Github

Project Overview

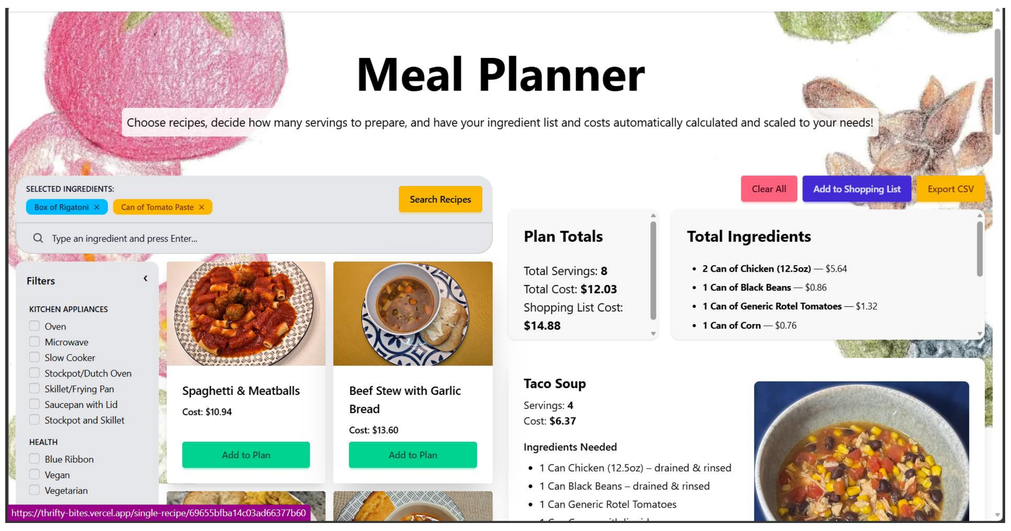


Recipe Search and Filter



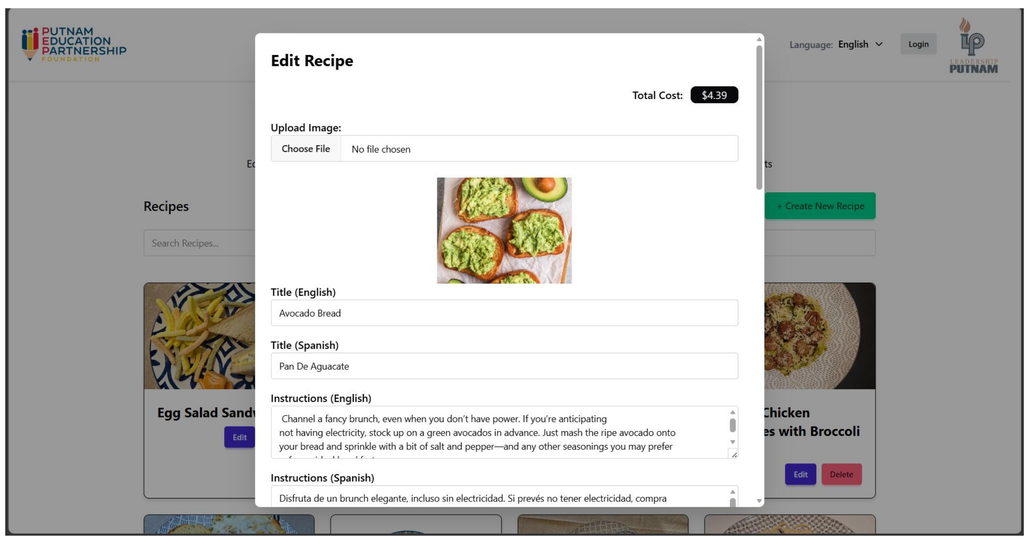
We have advanced recipe filtering and searching features aimed at convenience for our users. Currently you can search by ingredients, filter by allergens, cost, appliances, and more.

Meal Planner



Our meal planner tool offers families and food bank staff a way to easily save recipes into a central shopping list. This can even be exported into an excel spreadsheet for further budgeting.

Admin Panel



Our admins have a secure panel that gives them access to a website editor. Changing recipes, resource links, and images is currently available.

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